

Title: Syntactic Convergence in Long-Term Bilingual Communities

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Abstract

Bilingual communities with sustained language contact often exhibit structural convergence, where the syntax of one language shifts toward patterns of the other. This study examines word order variation among third-generation heritage speakers in two long-established bilingual communities, comparing their grammatical judgments to monolingual baselines.

1. Introduction

While lexical borrowing between contact languages is well documented, structural convergence at the syntactic level is comparatively understudied, particularly in communities where contact has persisted across multiple generations rather than occurring through recent migration.

2. Methods

We administered grammaticality judgment tasks to 96 heritage speakers and 60 monolingual controls, focusing on relative clause attachment and verb-final versus verb-medial constructions. Judgments were analyzed using mixed-effects models controlling for age of acquisition and frequency of heritage language use.

3. Results

Heritage speakers showed significantly higher acceptance of contact-language-consistent word orders that would be judged ungrammatical by monolingual speakers, with acceptance rates correlating strongly with self-reported frequency of code-switching in daily life.

4. Discussion

These results support a usage-based account of syntactic convergence, in which structural change emerges gradually from patterns of everyday bilingual production rather than from a single generation of abrupt reanalysis.

5. Conclusion

Long-term bilingual contact produces measurable syntactic convergence that intensifies with generational depth and everyday code-switching frequency, offering a window into how contact-induced change accumulates over time.